Maultsby turn 10 degrees left, but then another voice suggested doing the opposite—turn 30 degrees right.

Unbeknownst to Maultsby, the second voice belonged to a Soviet controller who had spotted the U-2 flying over the Chukotka Peninsula, a thousand miles west of his route and Barter Island, with its radio beacon. The fact that Maultsby had been spotted by Soviet radar over the sovereign airspace of the USSR put him in danger, but Strategic Air Command intelligence officers at Offutt Air Force Base in Nebraska, who were spying on Soviet radar signals, had intercepted the Soviet controller's message and also learned Maultsby's position. Yet this did not mean that Maultsby would be rescued from his predicament, because SAC was not about to reveal its successful monitoring of Soviet radar signals.

Maultsby was unaware that ever since he crossed into Soviet airspace and heard the unfamiliar voice on his sideband radio, he had been hunted by Soviet jet fighters, which took off from their air bases in Pevek and, ironically, Anadyr, the town that shared its name with the Soviet Cuban operation. The SAC intelligence officers in Nebraska were tracking Maultsby's route and the Soviet jets speeding toward his plane but could do nothing without revealing their monitoring to the Soviets.[5]

In fact, they did not have to do anything. Soviet MIG fighters could not reach the high altitude at which the light U-2 plane was flying. The two MiG-17P all-weather fighter jets from the 25th Fighter Division of Air Defense Forces that were sent in pursuit of Maultsby's plane could fly at a speed of more than 1,000 kilometers per hour and reach an altitude of 15,600 meters in fifteen minutes, but that did not count for much against a U-2 plane flying at an altitude of more than 21,000 meters. The MiGs had no chance of catching the U-2 but, just in case, the Alaska Air Command dispatched two Convair F-102 Delta Dagger interceptors to protect their spy plane and, if necessary, confront the MiGs once Maultsby crossed into American airspace.[6]

The F-102s could rise as high as 16,300 meters or 53,400 feet, not enough to reach U-2 altitude but perfect for intercepting the Soviet fighters. The MiGs were armed with two 23 mm autocannons with eighty rounds of ammunition per gun and one 37 mm autocannon with forty rounds of ammunition. The F-102s had no guns but were armed with twenty-four